



Early break: Norsyafiq Sumantri gives Malaysia the lead with the opening goal against China. R. V. MOORTHY

explained Bangladesh coach Mosiur Rahman Biplob.

City of Kings

Rajgir, the ancient town in Bihar, proved a fortuitous host. Following the women's continental triumph earlier, the men too found success here.

For visiting teams like Japan, China, and Chinese Taipei, the trip was more than sport; it was a pilgrimage to a place steeped in Buddhist history. The Rajgir Sports Complex Hockey Stadium became both a stage for top-level competition and a classroom for its academy players, who not only watched the action from close quarters but also interacted with stars after the final.

If the organisation was efficient, the 4,000–5,000-seat capacity proved

inadequate. Spectators braved not just the heat but also cramped stands to cheer.

Big fish in a small pond?

Coach Fulton had set the tone before the tournament: "We intend to be the number one team in Asia always." His squad backed him up, extending his impressive tenure of three golds and a bronze in four events. His contract runs at least until the 2026 World Cup and Asian Games, with Hockey India firmly behind him.

The South African's blueprint is clear: use Asian competitions to build depth and cohesion while preparing to face Australia and European giants. Yet the question lingers — against a shallow continental pool, how much does India really learn?



Statistics

Goals scored: 164
Penalty Corner goals: 59
Top goal-scoring team: India (39)
Least goal-conceding team: Japan (6)

Individual Stats

Top-scorer: Akhimullah Anuar (Malaysia) — 12

Top-scorer for India: Harmanpreet Singh — 7

Most Penalty Corners scored: Harmanpreet Singh (India) — 6

Individual Awards

Promising Goalkeeper: Caiyu Wang (China)

Rising Star of the Tournament: Andywalfian Jeffrynus (Malaysia)

AHF Best Goalkeeper: Jaehan Kim (Korea)

Player of the Tournament: Abhishek (India)